apertures disguised in the temples' exterior surface decoration (Figure 6.8). Given these temples' notable formal (and structural) divergences from their north Indian cousins, they surely served different uses – some possibly defensive, as suggested by Meister.[28] They certainly housed localized rituals that seemed to distinguish Shaivite and other Brahmanical–Hindu religious practices in the region from those of the north Indian plains and elsewhere. Only further archaeological excavations and studies will clarify the contours of these important local developments. Indeed, the abilities of architectural traditions to meet localized ritual and other needs over time was further borne out into the twelfth century: as argued later in this chapter, the identifiable Shansabani architectural traces in the vicinity of the great city of Multan were in themselves further developments of the Gandhara–Nagara architectural canon.



Figure 6.5 *Temple, Mari Indus, West Panjab, Pakistan. © Photograph Alka Patel 1997.*

Sindh, Baluchistan, and the Makran Coast

In AH 578/1182 CE, the Ghazna Shansabani campaign to the renowned port of Dibul – now accepted to be the modern archaeological site of Banbhore[29] (Figure 6.9) – brought Mu'izz al-Din and his forces face to face with the commerce-driven, extremely prosperous, cosmopolitan region of coastal Sindh, which also extended to meet Gujarat toward the east, and to the west the Makran coast and its hinterlands in southern Baluchistan.[30] Merchandise and riches poured into and out of the area with equal vigor *via* the Indus, the mighty yet capricious river that served as an artery of the vast Indian Ocean world as it linked global maritime and overland routes.

Juzjani's description of Mu'izz al-Din's campaign as one "captur[ing] the whole of that seaside country" swept into broad strokes the many small and large entrepôts dedicated to the bustling flow of commerce, as well as the substantial urban centers that rose and fell depending on the Indus's